macOS basics for new Mac users

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Summary

This article introduces new Mac users to the essential features and daily workflows on Acme-Global managed macOS devices. It covers the desktop environment, core settings, common productivity tasks, security basics, simple troubleshooting steps, and guidance for the Desktop Support team when assisting users.

Symptoms

- User is unfamiliar with the macOS desktop layout
- User cannot locate System Settings or Apple Menu
- User needs to install approved software but does not know how to use Company Portal
- User receives a prompt for FileVault recovery key or MFA verification

Common causes

- New hardware or OS upgrade with no prior macOS experience
- Lack of orientation to Acme-Global's managed Mac policies (Intune, FileVault, MFA)

Getting to know the macOS desktop

When you log in, you see the menu bar at the top-left (Apple icon, app menus, status icons) and the Dock at the bottom (or side) containing frequently used apps. The desktop itself can hold files, folders, and shortcuts. Click the Apple menu ? to access System Settings, recent items, Log Out, and Shut Down. Use Spotlight (?-Space) to search for apps, documents, or settings instantly.

First-time setup self-help procedure

Follow these steps to configure your Mac for Acme-Global resources and personal preferences.

1. 1. Sign in with your corporate Azure AD account when prompted at first login.
2. 2. Open System Settings -> Apple ID and ensure your Acme-Global email is listed; enable iCloud Drive only if approved by your manager.
3. 3. Go to System Settings -> Privacy & Security -> FileVault and verify that encryption is ON (managed by Intune). Note the recovery key is stored in Intune; you do not need to record it.
4. 4. Enable Microsoft Authenticator push notifications: open the Authenticator app, add your Acme-Global account, and approve the push notification.
5. 5. Open Company Portal from the Applications folder, sign in, and install any required line-of-business apps (e.g., VPN client, approved development tools).
6. 6. Run Software Update from System Settings -> General -> Software Update to ensure you have the latest macOS security patches (Acme-Global pushes updates via Intune on Patch Tuesday).

Common daily tasks

Use Finder (the smiling-face icon) to browse files; you can add tags, create smart folders, and connect to network shares via Go -> Connect to Server (smb://files.acme.example). The Dock lets you launch Outlook, Teams, OneDrive, and Safari with a single click. To install apps from the Mac App Store, open the Store, search, and click Get; for line-of-business software, always use Company Portal to ensure proper licensing and configuration. To print, select Print in any app, choose the PaperCut printer 'print.acme.example', and release the job at any secure-print station using your ID badge.

Security basics and reporting

Your Mac is protected by Microsoft Defender for Endpoint and FileVault disk encryption. Keep your password strong (14+ characters, changed every 90?days) and never reuse the last ten passwords. If you receive a suspicious email, use the Outlook "Report Phishing" button or forward it to phishing@acme.example. For MFA, approve push notifications in Microsoft Authenticator; if you lose your device, contact the IAM team for a Temporary Access Pass. Never disable FileVault or turn off the firewall unless instructed by Desktop Support.

Basic troubleshooting and when to call the desk

If an app freezes, force-quit it with ?-Option-Esc, select the app, and click Force Quit. For system-wide sluggishness, restart the Mac (Apple menu -> Restart). If the Mac won't start up normally, hold the Shift key at boot to enter Safe Mode, which loads only essential extensions and can help isolate software issues. Check Console (Applications -> Utilities -> Console) for recent error logs if you notice repeated crashes. If the problem persists after a restart, Safe Mode check, or you are prompted for a FileVault recovery key you do not have, contact the IT Service Desk.

Service-desk agent procedure

Agents should verify the user's identity, confirm device compliance, and guide the user through the self-help steps above before escalating. Use Remote Help via Teams or Intune to view the screen, check FileVault status (System Settings -> Privacy & Security -> FileVault), and ensure the Company Portal shows compliant apps. Document any error messages, steps taken, and the user's Mac model and macOS version in the ticket.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Desktop Support L2 team when: the user cannot boot into macOS even in Safe Mode, FileVault recovery key is required and not available in Intune, or a persistent kernel panic occurs. Include in the escalation: Mac serial number, macOS version, Intune compliance state, exact error messages or panic codes, and a summary of troubleshooting steps already attempted.

Keywords: macOS basics, new Mac user, Apple menu, System Settings, FileVault, MFA, Microsoft Authenticator, Company Portal, Spotlight, Finder, Dock, Self-help procedure, Service desk agent, Intune, Defender for Endpoint, Printing, PaperCut, Safe Mode, Force quit, Escalation